

PIR - Donington colleagues were unable to print carrier labels

M&S Digital&Tech *Post Incident Review*



Incident Ref: 90633159

Incident Date: 27/02/25

PIR Date: 07/03/25

Author: Rehan Siddiqui

Attendees:

Davies, Mark; Srinivasan, Murali ; Martin, Jackie ; Tom Prince, Peter Davison; Donald Graham; Vasan, Pragadeesh Krishnan, Gokula Vijayan, Pavithra

Technical Owner:

- Analyses the root cause and provide technical recommendations to prevent incident recurrence.*
- Develop and oversee the implementation of an action plan to address the root causes.*
- Work closely with cross-functional teams to gather information and insights.*

Tom Prince - Sorted

PIR Reviewer:

- Validates the root cause analysis, corrective actions, and preventive measures before signing off, ensuring alignment with business and operational standards.*

Martin, Jackie

1. Incident Summary :

- Provide a concise overview of the incident with brief update on issue, impact, root cause and resolution.*

Donington colleagues were unable to print carrier labels from 23:45 impacting packing operations resulting in capability loss of 43k singles and CFR of 331 orders. The initial root cause was attributed to an issue with Royal Mail sequence service going out of range. Services were restored after the range was amended followed by restarting the service by 03:00 (28/02). Root cause investigations underway with Sorted

2. Incident Chronology :

- Include a record of the data/time of key events. e.g. "07:36 Incident started, notified by ..." **keep fact based**".*

This incident was not managed by the MIM team and MIM engagement has been addressed as part of the actions below.

27/02/2025

23:30 - Alert triggered for increasing number of Royal Mail allocation failures.

23:45 - Sorted On call engineer begins investigation.

28/02/2025

00:35 - Incident started.

01:45 - Sorted support called out by M&S. Investigation confirms that allocation failures caused by exhausted Royal Mail range for M&S.

02:11 - New range requested from Royal Mail via API call and sent to engineering to implement.

02:35 - We could see customer is allocating successfully with Royal Mail service after new range was implemented.

3. Incident Resolution

👉 *The actions taken to restore services and mitigate impact.*

Once it was established that the allocation failures were being caused by the depleted Royal Mail range, a new range was requested and implemented, which restored service.

4. Root Cause

👉 *Refers to the fundamental reason (s) why an incident occurred including problem description, analysis techniques, contributing factors, evidence with concise root cause statements*

Allocation failures were caused by the range for the Royal Mail service used by M&S Castle Donnington location running out.

The alert which should have triggered when the range reached 0% did not trigger due to a human error - an inadvertent typo by Sorted when setting up the Royal Mail range.

Sorted have a monitor in place to alert them when a carrier range is close to exhaustion so that they can request and implement a new one, but this range was not picked up by this monitor. This was because the range didn't follow the convention for naming.

5. Findings

👉 *Refer to the key insights and conclusions drawn from the incident analysis - what went well/what went wrong highlighting gaps, failures, or inefficiencies.*

5.1. Observability –

👉 *Evaluating monitoring, logging, and alerting effectiveness in detecting the incident.*

The alert that Sorted has configured only indicated allocation failures. There are alerts in place to trigger for carrier ranges running out and these trigger when 20% of the range is left. However due to the human error when setting up the range, the naming convention was not recognised and the alert did not trigger resulting in the technical team having to investigate further.

5.2. Technical Challenges -

👉 *Identifying system, infrastructure, or architectural issues that complicated resolution.*

As the alert for the range running out did not trigger, the investigation took around two hours. The reason for this is because the IT support team at CD were looking at various causes and systems such as WMS etc.

5.3. MIM involvement & impact assessment -

👉 *Timely engagement of MIM and analysing the impact on business operations based on top 10 business processes*

Gap in impact assessment.

MIM not engaged. CD IT support ran the call themselves. The process will now be reviewed with the team.

5.4. Incident handling/ stakeholder management –

👉 *Reviewing how teams collaborated to drive the incident to resolution and engaged with key stakeholders.*

⊕ Martin, Jackie called out that the out of hours process was followed very well by CD IT Onsite support team.

5.5. Business Communication –

👉 *Clear, concise & timely communication to stakeholders, focusing on business impact and recovery actions.*

Internal comms handled well but formal comms missing as MIM were not engaged and this process will be reviewed

5.6. Supplier Engagement –

👉 *Assessing the responsiveness and support provided by external vendors and internal product teams.*

The PIR attendees agree that Sorted were engaged in a timely manner and unfortunately had to spend two hours investigating the issue as the alert had not triggered. The action plan below addresses the need to have a failover plan to other carriers so that any impact can be mitigated in a timely manner.

Mitigation Actions:

👉 Agree actions for each of the findings to prevent recurrence, strengthen system reliability & stability, and improve response efficiency for future incidents

	≡ Action	≡ Owner	📅 Due Date	≡ Remarks	🏷️ Action Category
1	Check that all existing carrier ranges have the correct names and will be picked up by our monitor.	Sorted		Completed	Problem Avoidance
2	Review the other carriers that are used and check if the range can potentially run out for these other carriers?	Sorted		Completed. The other carrier where the range has to manually set up is Anpost. Other carriers have cyclical range creation and these are ranges are created in an automated way.	Problem Avoidance
3	Have Sorted got alerting for the other carriers if the range runs low?	Sorted		Completed. Range depletion alerting is in place for Anpost and the naming convention checked to ensure it meets the correct format,	Problem Avoidance
4	If the issue happens again with any carrier, is there an option to switch to the next carrier, even if the price is higher? What process needs to be put in place and how?	⊕ Martin, Jackie	Fri, Mar 21, 2025	Tom Prince advises this is possible. We don't have M&S carrier team support team out of hours after 2200. Therefore a SOP be written for Sort out of hours support so they can switch carriers. Sorted and M&S carrier team to agree.	Problem Avoidance

Please refer to [Major_ Significant and Key Incident Tracker v1.0.xlsx](#) for progress updates on Mitigations

<Mandatory participants: Put it in the meeting invite. >

Technical Details and Useful Documents: